

TO-DO-LIST

WHEN FACING ADVERSITY

Blue indicates power point slide

Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: James 1:1-8 (NKJV) *“James, a bondservant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ, To the twelve tribes which are scattered abroad: Greetings. ² My brethren, count it all joy when you fall into various trials, ³ knowing that the testing of your faith produces patience. ⁴ But let patience have its perfect work, that you may be perfect and complete, lacking nothing. ⁵ If any of you lacks wisdom, let him ask of God, who gives to all liberally and without reproach, and it will be given to him. ⁶ But let him ask in faith, with no doubting, for he who doubts is like a wave of the sea driven and tossed by the wind. ⁷ For let not that man suppose that he will receive anything from the Lord; ⁸ he is a double-minded man, unstable in all his ways.”*

INTRO: The definition of adversity is, “A state, condition, or instance of serious or continued difficulty or adverse fortune.”

The one commonality shared by all humans is the onslaught of adversity. Adversity knows no prejudice: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- It comes to the just and the unjust...
- It attacks the rich and the poor...
- It rolls up on the young and the old...
- It assails the defenseless and the capable...
- It attaches itself to the prepared and the unprepared...

No one is exempt from adversity! We have all either dealt with it; are dealing with it; or will deal with it! Someone said *“Everyone either has a problem, knows a problem, or is a problem!”* I say, *“God help you if you are all three!”*

Jesus warned us about adversity in John 16:33 (NKJV) ***“In the world you will have tribulation...”*** Jesus declared that ALL of us would have times when we encounter adversity! All of us have wanted to wave the white flag of surrender when we face:

- A financial reversal...
- The loss of employment...
- A bad report from the doctor...

- The termination of a marriage...
- The breakup of a relationship...
- Being informed a child is behaving stupidly...
- Emotional problems that one cannot seem to conquer...

Look at the context of what Jesus had to say about adversity. John 16:33 (NKJV) ***“These things I have spoken to you, that in Me you may have peace. In the world you will have tribulation; but be of good cheer, I have overcome the world.”***

Psalm 42:5 (AMP) ***“Why are you cast down, O my inner self? And why should you moan over me and be disquieted within me? Hope in God and wait expectantly for Him, for I shall yet praise Him, Who is the help of my sad countenance, and my God.”*** Disquieted means internal rage. How many times have we allowed adversity to morph into internal rage?

- Raging at things...
- Raging at people...
- Raging at circumstances...
- Raging at family members...

- Raging at God...

When my soul is raging I have to break out my calm down and cheer up scriptures!

Calm down: John 14:27 (AMP) *“Peace I leave with you; My own peace I now give and bequeath to you. Not as the world gives do I give to you. Do not let your hearts be troubled, neither let them be afraid. Stop allowing yourselves to be agitated and disturbed; and do not permit yourselves to be fearful and intimidated and cowardly and unsettled.”*

Cheer up: John 16:33 (AMP) *“I have told you these things, so that in Me you may have perfect peace and confidence. In the world you have tribulation and trials and distress and frustration; but be of good cheer take courage; be confident, certain, undaunted! For I have overcome the world. I have deprived it of power to harm you and have conquered it for you.”*

So how do we dig our way out from under the adversity we find ourselves trapped in, and get to the place of having ***“peace”*** and ***“being of good cheer”***?

In our Scripture text James gives us a To-Do-List with four action items:

- Count...
- Let...
- Ask...
- Receive...

I. COUNT...

The word James uses here is an accounting term. Accountants are constantly counting things. We lovingly call them “*Bean counters.*” They think in numbers! (Andrew Lax, Carolyn Russell, Vicki Lee)

I am constantly counting things. (Illustrate this)

People usually count things because they believe it is going to help them assess a situation or bring resolution to something. Or, they just have a bad case of obsessive-compulsive disorder, better known as being OCD.

James says “*Count it all joy... When you face adversity...*” I can’t believe he said that! I wish he had not said that! If I ignore him can I avoid adversity? No!

He said this because he knew we would all face problems and he is attempting to prepare us to properly deal with the issues of life!

Can you find the joy in the trial you face?

(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE) Trust me, its there! The

illusive thing about discovering joy in adversity is that one must look long enough and dig deep enough to find it!

I can think of quite a number of people in this very congregation who stared down adversity, and have lived long enough to see the benefit that has sprang from such an episode:

- Doug and Audrey Turnbull - Made them better parents...
- Darrell and Tonya Mayfield – When Tonya’s brother and sister-in-law were tragically killed in an automobile accident – Their heart was enlarged to include three orphaned children...
- When Dr. Mike Holmes had a bout with cancer he found out who the real healer is...
- When Andrew and Tina Lax endured a financial meltdown they discovered who their real source is...

- When Ricky and Vicki Lee's children were devastated by a tornado they discovered who the real protector is...

William Arthur Ward said, *"Adversity causes some people to break and others to break records!"* **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)**

What we see as a life-threatening storm and it is nothing more than an interrupted nap for Jesus! Matthew 8:24-26 (NKJV) ***"Suddenly a great tempest arose on the sea, so that the boat was covered with the waves. But He was asleep. ²⁵ Then His disciples came to Him and awoke Him, saying, "Lord, save us! We are perishing!" ²⁶ But He said to them, "Why are you fearful, O you of little faith?" Then He arose and rebuked the winds and the sea, and there was a great calm."***

Jesus talked about counting the joy in adversity in this way. Hebrews 12:2 (NKJV) ***"Looking unto Jesus, the author and finisher of our faith, who for the joy that was set before Him endured the cross, despising the shame, and has sat down at the right hand of the throne of God.*** How could Jesus face the cross talking about the ***"Joy set before him"***? He knew full

well what awaited Him between Friday and Sunday!

Through it all, He was able to maintain his joyful perspective because He was looking beyond Sunday to:

- Conquering the keys of death and hell...
- Freeing of Old Testament Saints held in captivity...
- The suspense of the first Easter morning...
- The exhilaration of Bethany's launching pad...
- Being reseated at the right hand of the Father...
- The deployment of Holy Ghost Power for believers... (Illustrate this by talking about our first Christmas with our grandchildren)
- The office of intercession for all believers...
- The second coming in the clouds of Heaven...

When we face adversity we may have to:
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Drill down deeper to obtain it...

- Give sacrificially to receive it...
- Look beyond some things to see it...
(Rylee looking around me to see her mom
– **PICTURE OF RYLEE & ME AT GRINGOS**)
- Turn a deaf ear to some people to hear it... (Pastoral words – Really – Huh – Well – You’re kidding – Imagine that)
- Ignore some circumstances to discover it...
- Fight demons and devils to lay-hold of it... (Braden and his car – **PLACE PICTURE OF BRADEN AND HIS CAR ON THE SCREEN**)
- Get a distance down the road to take delivery of it...

Trust me, if we do the “*count*” on our present trial there is some joy in it somewhere! Martin Tucker said, “*He who does not tire, tires adversity.*”

In our text, James encourages each of us not to wait to rejoice in adversity until we can see the reason for joy, but to do so in faith!

If our Heavenly Father allowed it, something good must be going to come out of it!

(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE END OF THE SERVICE)

If I trust my Father I should be able to “*Count it all joy when I suffer adversity*”

One thing I know about each trial we face is that if we handle it right, we are going to receive a blessing, and God is going to get the glory!

II. LET...

To the casual reader this may not be too significant, but to the audience James was speaking to, this passage is jam-packed with meaning. This is a letter being penned to those who have been scattered to the four winds, mostly as a result of extreme persecution.

Against this backdrop James has the audacity to say, “*My brethren, count it all joy when you fall into various trials, ³ knowing that the testing of your faith produces patience. ⁴ But let patience have its perfect work, that you may be perfect and complete, lacking nothing.”*

The word “*let*” in this passage is *scheo* (skay-o) and means, “*to turn one’s mind over to.*” Let is a primary verb and quite literally it is the same

word that we get the statement we use in marriage vows - “*to have and to hold*”.

The King James version say’s “***Let patience have HER perfect work...***” The placement of the feminine state of patience suggests to me that patience has the power to give birth! The exercising of patience can give birth to victory, conversely the lack of patience will abort the plan God has for your adversity!

A.A. Milne said, “*Rivers know this: there is no hurry. We shall get there some day.*”

Hebrews 10:35-39 (NKJV) “***Do not cast away your confidence, which has great reward.***

³⁶ ***For you have need of endurance, so that after you have done the will of God, you may receive the promise:*** ³⁷ “***For yet a little while, And He who is coming will come and will not tarry.*** ³⁸ ***Now the just shall live by faith; But if anyone draws back, My soul has no pleasure in him.***” This is a powerful passage of Scripture and it speaks directly to the subject of patience:

- Enough confidence to exercise patience reaps great dividends...
- The believer must seek to be patient at all times...

- There will be a time lapse between doing the will of God and receiving the promise of God...
- He who has promised is faithful to deliver on all His promises...
- The just live with a patient confidence in the God they have chosen to follow...
- God takes no pleasure in those who do not have enough faith to exercise patience...

The use of the word “*patience*” indicates the reader will be the one who determines the outcome of the trial they are faced with, and that outcome would be determined by how married they are to patience. Each individual believer will decide whether the outcome will be: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Good or bad...
- Pleasant or unpleasant...
- Satisfying or unsatisfying...
- Enjoyable or miserable...
- Agreeable or disagreeable...
- Wonderful or horrible...

Benjamin Franklin once said, “*He that can have patience can have what he will.*”

I have a word for the weary; Galatians 6:9
(NKJV) “*And let us not grow weary while
doing good, for in due season we shall reap if
we do not lose heart.”*

Here are the facts concerning adversity:
**(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A
TIME)**

- They rarely give us much lead-time...
- They come at the most inconvenient times...
- They tend to drain us of energy and resources...
- They tend to last longer than we would like...
- They rarely make room for others to participate...

There is an old song that say's “*On the Jericho road there's room for just two; no more and no less, just Jesus and you.*” How true! Adversity tends to isolate its subjects!

Look at he Scriptural facts concerning patience:

- Patience produces fruit... Luke 8:15
- Patience conquers the soul... Luke 21:19
- Patience creates hope... Romans 15:4

- Patience generates strength and might...
Colossians 1:11
- Paul told Timothy to pursue patience... 1
Timothy 6:11

Aristotle said, *“Patience is bitter, but its fruit is sweet.”*

The really great stories of the Bible begin and end with patience:

- Noah saved the human race by letting patience have its perfect work...
- Abraham became the father of a nation by letting patience have its perfect work...
- Moses prepared the Children of Israel for Canaan by letting patience have its perfect work...
- David created a Kingdom that will never end by letting patience have its perfect work...
- Nehemiah rebuilt Jerusalem by letting patience have its perfect work...
- Jesus finished the work of redemption by letting patience have its perfect work...
- The disciples carried on the work of Christ by letting patience have its perfect work...

- Paul jump-started the New Testament Church by letting patience have its perfect work...
- The heroes of the faith achieved the miraculous by letting patience have its perfect work...

If we allow patience to have its perfect work,
“We will be perfect and complete, lacking nothing.”

Recipe for staying the course when confronted with adversity: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME THEN LEAVE ALL ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE END OF THE SERVICE)**

- Extra large portion of dependence on God...
- Apply equal measure of trust in the Lord...
- Stir in a pinch or two of faith for each situation...
- Mix thoroughly with enough persistence for good consistency...
- Let everything settle until God speaks...

III. ASK...

Words are important! Words are important to us but they are also important to God!

God created the world with words! **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** Genesis 1:3-27 (NKJV)

- Vs. 3 - *“God said, “Let there be light”; and there was light.”*
- Vs.6 - *“Then God said, “Let there be a firmament in the midst of the waters, and let it divide the waters from the waters.”*
- Vs. 9 – *“Then God said, “Let the waters under the heavens be gathered together into one place, and let the dry land appear”; and it was so.”*
- Vs. 11 – *“Then God said, “Let the earth bring forth grass, the herb that yields seed, and the fruit tree that yields fruit according to its kind, whose seed is in itself, on the earth”; and it was so.”*
- Vs. 14 – *“Then God said, “Let there be lights in the firmament of the heavens to divide the day from the night; and let them be for signs and seasons, and for days and years; ¹⁵ and let them be for lights in the firmament of the heavens to give light on the earth”; and it was so.*

- Vs. 20 – *“Then God said, “Let the waters abound with an abundance of living creatures, and let birds fly above the earth across the face of the firmament of the heavens.” ²¹ So God created great sea creatures and every living thing that moves, with which the waters abounded, according to their kind, and every winged bird according to its kind. And God saw that it was good”*
- Vs. 24 – *“Then God said, “Let the earth bring forth the living creature according to its kind: cattle and creeping thing and beast of the earth, each according to its kind”; and it was so.”*
- Vs. 26 – *“Then God said, “Let Us make man in Our image, according to Our likeness; let them have dominion over the fish of the sea, over the birds of the air, and over the cattle, over all the earth and over every creeping thing that creeps on the earth.”*

James say's if we ask for wisdom God will ***“give liberally.”*** I cannot explain everything I know about the power of words but I know words are powerful: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Words bring life and words bring death... Proverbs 18:21 (NKJV) ***“Death and life are in the power of the tongue, And those who love it will eat its fruit.”*** If we are walking through adversity we need to be asking for life and refusing to speak death! Proverbs 13:2-3 (NKJV) ***“A man shall eat well by the fruit of his mouth, But the soul of the unfaithful feeds on violence. ³ He who guards his mouth preserves his life, But he who opens wide his lips shall have destruction.”***
- Words determine our health... Proverbs 12:18 (NKJV) ***“There is one who speaks like the piercings of a sword, But the tongue of the wise promotes health.”*** In the midst of adversity the question we need to be asking ourselves is whether or not our words are relieving or complicating our circumstances?
- Words have the power to establish things in our lives... Job 22:28 (NKJV) ***“You will also declare a thing, And it will be established for you.”*** The word “*established*” here is “*quwm*” (koom) and means “*to arise and come on the scene.*” What are we asking for in our adversity? We need to be asking for the moon and speaking positive things, because as a

believer, whatever is coming out of our mouth is arising and coming on the scene!

- Words are the well-spring of life or the kiss of death... Proverbs 16:21-24 (NKJV) ***"The wise in heart will be called prudent, And sweetness of the lips increases learning. ²² Understanding is a wellspring of life to him who has it. But the correction of fools is folly. ²³ The heart of the wise teaches his mouth, And adds learning to his lips. ²⁴ Pleasant words are like a honeycomb, Sweetness to the soul and health to the bones."*** In the midst of adversity we must make sure our words are creating a well of resources and blessing rather than a dry hole of disappointment!
- Words filter down into the fabric of our being... Proverbs 18:8 (NKJV) ***"The words of a talebearer are like tasty trifles, And they go down into the inmost body."*** (Ever been around someone who is extremely negative and watched the response of those around them? Rolling the eyes, etc...) As believers we must not allow our words to define us as a pessimist! No matter how difficult the circumstances, we should remain extremely optimistic; the King of Kings

and Lord of Lords is working on our behalf!

- Words sentence us or free us... Numbers 35:30 (NKJV) “*Whoever kills a person, the murderer shall be put to death on the testimony of witnesses; but one witness is not sufficient testimony against a person for the death penalty.*” If the devil has placed us on trial, we should quit testifying against ourselves! One of the most difficult things a person faces is the ability to forgive oneself! We are not required to testify against ourselves! Refuse to take the stand! While facing down adversity we should only tell the positive part of our testimony!

We are what we say! Proverbs 18:20 (NKJV) “*A man’s stomach shall be satisfied from the fruit of his mouth; From the produce of his lips he shall be filled.*” When we face adversity we would do well to remember, we are what we say! More importantly, we will have what we say!

Look at some Biblical examples of the power of words in the lives of those we look up to:
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Joshua refused to allow the people to say a word at Jericho until the seventh day, and then they were only allowed to give a shout of praise to God! The reason? The last time they had an opportunity to get into the Promised Land their words kept them out!
- God had to shut the mouth of Zacharias so Elizabeth could carry John the Baptist to term! Zacharias was operating in doubt and his words threatened to abort the plan of God! He was mute for several months during the pregnancy and while a discussion ensued concerning what the baby's name would be, he wrote ***"He will be called John"*** at that point God gave him back his voice because he could then be trusted! Sometimes in the midst of adversity we would be better off being mute! Our to do list should be to speak the promises rather than spewing doubt! Proverbs 21:23 (NKJV) ***"Whoever guards his mouth and tongue Keeps his soul from troubles."***
- When Jesus stood before His accusers He refused to speak, not because He did not have an answer but because if He defended Himself against the false accusations, His words would have

prevented Him from going to the cross!
His defense would have literally
prevented the completion of salvations
plan!

Without the intervention of God's kingdom rule
through prayer, earth's circumstances will
succumb to inevitable consequences.

If Jehovah is our God, we should not just be
asking, we should be remaining optimistic and
asking BIG!

So you are facing adversity? What are you
asking of God that only He can do? What are
you asking of God that would register in the
miracle department!

Don't be timid in your prayers! Prayer should
be as big as God's promises and as full as
God's resources. Your requests should require
the full power and provision of God!

Asking BIG tends to solicit a BIG answer from
God!

*(A True Story By Helen Roseveare, Missionary
to Africa)*

One night, in Central Africa, I had worked hard

to help a mother in the labor ward; but in spite of all that we could do, she died leaving us with a tiny, premature baby and a crying, two-year-old daughter. We would have difficulty keeping the baby alive. We had no incubator or electricity to run an incubator. Although we lived on the equator, nights were often chilly with treacherous drafts.

A student-midwife went for the box we had for such babies and for the cotton wool that the baby would be wrapped in. Another went to stoke up the fire and fill a hot water bottle. She came back shortly, in distress, to tell me that in filling the bottle, it had burst, "*and it is our last hot water bottle*" she exclaimed.

In Central Africa water bottles do not grow on trees, and there are no drugstores down forest pathways. "*All right,*" I said, "*Put the baby as near the fire as you safely can; sleep between the baby and the door to keep it free from drafts. Your job is to keep the baby warm.*"

At noon the following day, as I did most days, I went to have prayers with many of the orphanage children. I gave the youngsters various suggestions of things to pray about and told them about the tiny baby. I explained our

problem about keeping the baby warm enough, mentioning the hot water bottle. I also told them about the two-year-old sister, crying because her mother had died. During the prayer time, one ten-year-old girl by the name of Ruth, prayed with the usual blunt consciousness of our African children, *"Please, God, send us a water bottle, it'll be no good tomorrow, God, the baby will be dead; so, please send it this afternoon."* While I gasped inwardly at the audacity of the prayer, she added *"...And while You are about it, would You please send a dolly for the little girl so she'll know You really love her?"*

As often with children's prayers, I was put on the spot. Could I honestly say, *"Amen?"* I just did not believe that God could do this! Oh, yes, I know that He can do everything: The Bible says so, but there are limits, aren't there? The only way God could answer this particular prayer would be by sending a parcel from the homeland. I had been in Africa for almost four years at that time, and I had never, ever received a parcel from home. Anyway, if anyone did send a parcel, who would put in a hot water bottle?

Halfway through the afternoon, while I was

teaching in the nurses' training school, a message was sent that there was a car at my front door. By the time I reached home, the car had gone, but there, on the veranda, was a large twenty-two pound parcel! I felt tears pricking my eyes. I could not open the parcel alone; so, I sent for the orphanage children. Some thirty or forty pairs of eyes were focused on the large cardboard box. From the top, I lifted out brightly colored, knitted jerseys. Eyes sparkled as I gave them out. Then, there were the knitted bandages for the leprosy patients, and the children began to look a little bored. Next, came a box of mixed raisins. As I put my hand in again, I felt the... could it really be? I grasped it, and pulled it out. Yes, "*A brand-new hot water bottle!*" I cried. I had not asked God to send it; I had not truly believed that He could. Ruth was in the front row and she rushed forward, crying out, "*If God has sent the bottle, He must have sent the dolly, too!*" Rummaging down to the bottom of the box, she pulled out the small, beautifully dressed doll!

That parcel had been on the way for five whole months, packed up by my former Sunday School class, whose leader had heard and obeyed God's prompting to send a hot water bottle! One of the girls had put in a doll for an

African child -- five months earlier in answer to the believing prayer of a ten-year-old to bring it "That afternoon!"

Isaiah 65:24 (KJV) *"And it shall come to pass, that before they call, I will answer; and while they are yet speaking, I will hear."* (LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE END OF THE SERVICE)

IV. RECEIVE...

What is being asked for here is wisdom and of course we know *"Wisdom is the principle thing"* that we need in our lives. Therefore James declares that we can ask for wisdom and expect to receive what we have requested.

Not only should we expect to receive, our expectation should be that *when God delivers on our request He will go beyond what we have asked for.* (LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLID) James 1:5

(NKJV) *"If any of you lacks wisdom, let him ask of God, who gives to all liberally and without reproach, and it will be given to him."*

This literally means, *"When we ask, God will give generously and not cop an attitude."* (My translation) Susan would say, *"He will go way past our way past!"*

In every trial the first thing we should ask for is wisdom. Without wisdom we could literally get the need supplied and be back in an even more difficult spot in a few days. Even though ***“Wisdom is the principle thing”*** James lets us know the will of the Father is ***“That we may be perfect and complete, lacking nothing.”***

I would like to point out five factors that are common denominators in receiving from the Lord:

1) Realize we are in need of help from the Lord... Most of us are extremely self-sufficient! As a result, we rarely turn to God until we have nowhere else to turn! Usually we engage in self-help action until we have gone from a minor problem to needing an outright miracle. Then and only then, do we call on God! When we finally call on God we expect Him to deliver in thirty minutes or else!

Three things we should remember when we are in lack: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- We are able to control the outcome of some difficulties!
- Some circumstances are beyond our control!
- Whether or not we have any control, God

will guide every circumstance to a satisfactory conclusion, if we will trust and obey Him!

Being in a place of lack is not what God wants for us and it is certainly an uncomfortable spot but we must always remember desperation is the stuff miracles are made out of! James 1:4 (NKJV) ***“Let patience have its perfect work, that you may be perfect and complete, lacking nothing.”***

The cry of the desperate is an emergency siren to the ears of a God who ***“Rides on the wings of the wind for our help.”***

Mark 6:47-51 (NKJV) ***“When evening came, the boat was in the middle of the sea; and He was alone on the land. ⁴⁸ Then He saw them (The disciples) straining at rowing, for the wind was against them. Now about the fourth watch of the night He came to them, walking on the sea, and would have passed them by.***

⁴⁹ And when they saw Him walking on the sea, they supposed it was a ghost, and cried out;

⁵⁰ for they all saw Him and were troubled. But immediately He talked with them and said to them, “Be of good cheer! It is I; do not be afraid.” ⁵¹ Then He went up into the boat to

them, and the wind ceased. And they were greatly amazed in themselves beyond measure, and marveled.”

2) Ask with an attitude! James 1:5-6a (NKJV)
“If any of you lacks wisdom, let him ask of God, who gives to all liberally and without reproach, and it will be given to him. ⁶ But let him ask in faith, with no doubting...”

There are two attitudes we can approach God with: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Confidence...
- Worry...

Confidence – Hebrews 10:35 (NKJV) *“Do not cast away your confidence, which has great reward.”* The word confidence here means to *“Speak in a bold manner.”* Hebrews 4:16 (NKJV) *“Let us therefore come boldly to the throne of grace, that we may obtain mercy and find grace to help in time of need.”* The word **“Boldly”** means: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Free and fearless confidence...
- Cheerful courage...
- Assurance...

(Illustrate this by bringing up someone who is

not related to me and have him or her to ask me for something – Then have one of my kids to come up and ask me for the very same thing)

When we ask something of the Father we should never ask in an arrogant manner but we should always ask in a boldly confident manner.

In Acts three Peter and John were on their way to church and a lame man asked them for money. This was not at all unusual; this was his usual spot for making his living. He was no doubt there every single day and Peter and John had more than likely given him money many times. Notice what the Scripture say's happened; Acts 3:5 (NKJV) ***“He gave them his attention expecting to receive something from them.”*** The lame man asked in an expectant manner and as you know, he received far more than he asked for. Acts 3:6-8 (NKJV) ***“Peter said, “Silver and gold I do not have, but what I do have I give you: In the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, rise up and walk.”⁷ And he took him by the right hand and lifted him up, and immediately his feet and ankle bones received strength.⁸ So he, leaping up, stood and walked and entered the temple with them—walking, leaping, and praising God.”*** He asked for alms in a confident manner and got

legs!

When we face difficulty it is easy for us to allow ourselves to begin to explore the world of worry! Someone described worry like this:

“Worry is the trickle of fear that meanders through the mind, cutting a channel into that which all other thoughts flow.”

John R. Rice said, *“Worry is putting question marks where God has put Periods.”* **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** Bishop Fulton J. Sheen called worry, *“A form of atheism, for it portrays a lack of faith and trust in God.”*

But for some of us, worry seems as inherent as breathing. Most of us do not feel that we have done our due diligence until we have worried sufficiently in difficult times. Worry is the enemy of faith!

Listen to the words of Jesus on the subject of worry. Matthew 6:25-34 (CEV) ***“I tell you not to worry about your life. Don’t worry about having something to eat, drink, or wear. Isn’t life more than food or clothing? 26 Look at the birds in the sky! They don’t plant or harvest. They don’t even store grain in barns.*”**

Yet your Father in heaven takes care of them. Aren't you worth more than birds? 27 Can worry make you live longer? 28 Why worry about clothes? Look how the wild flowers grow. They don't work hard to make their clothes. 29 But I tell you that Solomon with all his wealth wasn't as well clothed as one of them. 30 God gives such beauty to everything that grows in the fields, even though it is here today and thrown into a fire tomorrow. He will surely do even more for you! Why do you have such little faith? 31 Don't worry and ask yourselves, "Will we have anything to eat? Will we have anything to drink? Will we have any clothes to wear?" 32 Only people who don't know God are always worrying about such things. Your Father in heaven knows that you need all of these. 33 But more than anything else, put God's work first and do what he wants. Then the other things will be yours as well. 34 Don't worry about tomorrow. It will take care of itself. You have enough to worry about today."

Worry never causes God to act! In fact, God rarely acts until we turn to Him and turn it over to Him completely. The Lord dropped this in my heart as I was preparing for this sermon:

“Our point of desperation is God’s point of delivery!” **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** Are there any desperate people in here today? If you are desperate and have turned your situation over to God, you can get ready because Heaven’s delivery truck is backing up to your unloading dock even as we sit here today! **(PLAY BACKUP ALARM HERE)**

Philippians 4:6 (MSG) ***“Don’t fret or worry. Instead of worrying, pray. Let petitions and praises shape your worries into prayers, letting God know your concerns. 7 Before you know it, a sense of God’s wholeness, everything coming together for good, will come and settle you down. It’s wonderful what happens when Christ displaces worry at the center of your life.”***

So how do we go from asking with trepidation and worry to asking boldly? The Lord spoke this to me as I was preparing for this message: *“Asking confidently grows out of relationship.”* **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE END OF THE SERVICE)** (Go back to the illustration of someone unrelated to me asking me for something and my own child asking me

for the same thing – The difference?
Relationship)

We should begin converting our worries into prayers and our fears into faith. God will never send us to a place without furnishing the grace to do His will, or the stamina to maintain our sanity and integrity!

3) Believe God is our sole source!

Matthew 7:7-11 (CEV) ***“Ask, and you will receive. Search, and you will find. Knock, and the door will be opened for you. ⁸ Everyone who asks will receive. Everyone who searches will find. And the door will be opened for everyone who knocks. ⁹ Would any of you give your hungry child a stone, if the child asked for some bread? ¹⁰ Would you give your child a snake if the child asked for a fish? ¹¹ As bad as you are, you still know how to give good gifts to your children. But your heavenly Father is even more ready to give good things to people who ask.”***

Mark 11:22-24 (CEV) ***“Jesus told his disciples:
Have faith in God! ²³ If you have faith in God and don’t doubt, you can tell this mountain to***

get up and jump into the sea, and it will.
²⁴ *Everything you ask for in prayer will be yours, if you only have faith.”*

Do not doubt or change your mind!
Psalm 118:8 Psalm 37:3 Psalms 31:19
Proverbs 29:25

STAGGERED NOT

Rom 4:20....Abraham STAGGERED
NOT at the PROMISES of God....He
hoped against hope (hope here
means to “anticipate with
pleasure”)!!!!!!!

“stagger” means to waver or that he
was not divided in his mind by
unbelief!

Romans 4:20-21 (King James Version)

20He staggered not at the promise of God through unbelief; but was strong in faith, giving glory to God;

²¹And being fully persuaded that, what he had promised, he was able also to perform.

Romans 4:20-21 (The Message)

20He didn't tiptoe around God's promise asking cautiously skeptical questions. He plunged into the promise and came up strong, ready for God, ²¹sure that God would make good on what he had said.

Abraham's soul was full of confidence that the Word of God bound HIM to fulfill what He had promised. After 25 years it was fulfilled!!! WOW!

Remember this....God didn't promise He would answer your

prayer according to your schedule!
WOW!

Get ready to receive! ***“It shall be given to him.”*** Psalms 34:22 Psalms 37:5

APPLE TREE DESTINY

An apple trees needs no teaching or training whatsoever to realize its destiny to produce apples! Every tiny apple seed has all the instructions it ever needs within its own cellular structure to produce sweet fruit, the promise of its destiny!

You will never see an apple seed stressing out and feeling pressured over what it should do next! Why not? B/c the apple tree knows it is fully supplied with all its needs to produce sweet fruit! (Read John 1:16 in Amp) Glory!!!!!!

Jesus Christ, implanted within your born again spirit, is the incorruptible Seed of life! His full spiritual structure/stature is within that Seed placed into the born again spirits of all Christians....

Every promise made by God to Abraham became “encoded” into the incorruptible Seed of Christ’s life....which is now in you! I am amazed every time I realize that God chose us to be the soil for planting of the Seed of His promise! Our destiny is to be holy dirt!!!!!!!!!!!!!!

You have the fully “encoded and programmed” Seed of life and promise implanted in you as a believer! That Seed knows exactly what to do to work the good works of

God that have been uniquely
preordained and established in
heaven for you to do!!!!!!!!!!!!!!